

We may examine the careers of men who achieved mighty breakthroughs in their fields and we may marvel at the way in which they found their abilities and put them to effective use. At the same time we may see many of the obstacles they had to overcome. Rarely, however, do we know of the *adverse criticism* many such men faced. Had they feared this criticism and let it take root in their minds, all their ability to conceive and achieve might have been crippled. Indeed, they never might have felt it, for their minds would not have been free minds that drive ahead.

The automobile, of course, "would not work." Nor would the airplane. Nor would space travel. By the time Henry Ford was ready to manufacture automobiles on a mass production basis the automobile obviously worked, but mass production of such tricky devices was sneered at. They were a laboratory curiosity. Nobody could supply the gasoline necessary, nor the rubber, nor insure that such necessities would be available to a motorist wherever he might travel. Furthermore, said the bankers with whom Henry Ford preferred not to do business, people simply would not buy such a high-priced gadget in sufficient quantities. Almost everyone who knew of Ford's plans condemned them on one ground or another. Surely the sustaining power of love helped Ford to know his own mind, for Mrs. Ford said simply: "Go ahead no matter who criticizes."

More recently, a man named Henry Land took a photograph of his young daughter. She wanted to see the picture right away. He explained that first the roll of photographic paper must be taken out of the camera and developed in a darkroom by means of certain chemicals. Once the negatives were obtained, they had to be printed by intense light upon another kind of paper which in its turn needed chemical treatment; and so, at length, pictures would appear.

At this point his unhampered mind took hold. Why not build a camera which produced finished pictures? Anyone who knew anything about photography could have given him a dozen reasons why not—but criticism did not stay the development of the Land-Polaroid camera which does exactly what young Miss Land requested.

Criticism cripples as well in the realm of pure ideas. When I set out to organize the Science of Personal Achievement, I was almost snowed under by the criticism heaped upon my head. Most of the criticism came from my nearest relatives, and this is hard to take. I could not then have put in words